

Collective Intelligence — Module 06: Learning —

Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on knowledge management, collective memory, transactive memory, and communities of practice.

1. How does the SECI model (Nonaka) map onto the Active Inference concept of model updating? Which mode (socialization, externalization, combination, internalization) is hardest for organizations?
2. What is a transactive memory system, and how does it differ from a shared database? Why is knowing "who knows what" sometimes more valuable than storing explicit knowledge?
3. Wenger's communities of practice are informal. What happens when organizations try to formalize them? Does formalization help or hurt collective learning?
4. When an experienced employee leaves, what knowledge is lost? Distinguish between explicit knowledge (documentable) and tacit knowledge (only transferable through experience).
5. How do apprenticeship and mentoring transfer tacit knowledge? What is the Active Inference mechanism at work?
6. How does team turnover affect collective learning? Is some turnover beneficial (bringing fresh perspectives), or is stability always preferable?
7. Compare how a hospital, a software company, and a law firm manage institutional knowledge. What structural differences explain different approaches?
8. How do shared tools and repositories (wikis, code repositories, shared drives) contribute to collective memory? What are their limitations?

9. What is "organizational forgetting," and when is it adaptive (discarding outdated knowledge) versus pathological (losing valuable knowledge)?
10. How does the length of feedback loops affect collective learning? Compare teams that get feedback in hours (software deployment) versus months (product development).
11. Map the transactive memory system in your team. For 5 key knowledge domains, identify who holds the expertise. Is there redundancy? Single points of failure?
12. Describe a piece of important organizational knowledge that exists only in one person's head. Design a system to externalize it without losing the nuance of tacit understanding.
13. Design a "knowledge preservation protocol" for your team to use when a senior member departs. What would you do in the 30 days before they leave?
14. Evaluate the knowledge management tools your organization uses. Do they support all four SECI modes, or are they biased toward one or two?
15. A community of practice in your organization has become stale — the same people sharing the same ideas. How would you revitalize it while maintaining its value?
16. How does remote work affect the socialization mode of knowledge creation (tacit-to-tacit transfer through shared experience)?
17. Design an organization-wide learning system that connects learning across teams. How do insights from one team's experience become available to other teams?
18. Compare two approaches to post-project learning: written post-mortem reports versus storytelling sessions. Which captures more knowledge? Which is more likely to be used?
19. How does the concept of "prediction error" apply to collective learning? When a team project fails, what specific model components should be updated?
20. When is collective amnesia (deliberately forgetting past approaches) useful? How would you help a team unlearn a successful-but-now-outdated practice?